ARTS 1301: ART APPRECIATION | CRITICAL ANALYSIS MODULE

Mechanical Eyes and Machine Minds: From 19th-Century Photography to Generative AI (Assignment 2.2)

Assignment Overview

When photography emerged in the nineteenth century, critics, painters, and the general public fiercely debated whether a mechanical apparatus could ever produce fine art. The camera was initially dismissed as a mere technical recording device devoid of human spirit and imagination. Today, the art world faces an identical conceptual crisis surrounding artificial intelligence and algorithmic synthesis.

In this critical investigation, you will examine the initial chapters of John Andrews's 1892 *Studies in Photography*, deconstruct late-Victorian arguments on technology and aesthetic feeling, and apply those frameworks directly to a landmark contemporary controversy: Jason M. Allen winning first place at the 2022 Colorado State Fair with the AI-generated work *Théâtre D'opéra Spatial*.

Required Materials

Item	Source Description & Access Details
Primary Text	John Andrews, Studies in Photography (London: Hazell, Watson, & Viney, 1892). **Assigned Reading: Introduction, Chapter 1, and Chapter 2 (pp. 5–28).** ***Find these materials on Brightspace Week 11***
Video Case Study	News Broadcast: 'Colorado State Fair Digital Arts Competition AI Controversy' Focus: Jason M. Allen's award-winning entry 'Théâtre D'opéra Spatial' created via Midjourney. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=RnHeRf4KC78

Part 1: Close Reading and Textual Analysis

Answer each prompt thoroughly based strictly on John Andrews's arguments in the assigned chapters. Support each response with specific references to the reading, at least 50 words for each response.

- **The Facts of Photography as an Art Process:** What are the concrete facts and mechanical procedures of photography as detailed by Andrews? Based on how he evaluates these technical realities, what does he conclude is the true definition and purpose of art?

Answer) According to Andrews, photography requires mechanical equipment, which includes cameras, lenses, chemicals and printing processes to take images of nature. The photography can produce the details so accurate; however, he believes that technical accuracy on its own can't make fine art. He continues saying that sometimes photography captures some details which are unnecessary. A true art needs creative imagination, thoughtful composition, and artistic expression. The artist must need to transform what he is observing into a meaning not just reproduce reality (Andrews, pp.3-5, 12).

- **The Character of the True Artist:** According to Andrews, what differentiates an artist from a routine machine operator? Specifically, unpack his assertion that one must learn to 'wait and watch', what does this practice signify about artistic intentionality?

Answer) Andrew believes that true artist has patience, creativity, observation skills and have artistic feeling. An artist must study carefully the lightning, atmosphere, and composition before he creates an image. His advice of watching and waiting means an artist need thoughtful decisions rather than rushing. For example, an artist will wait the whole night to capture a magnificent view of sunlight. This is an example that the artistic intentions value more than just pressing a button (Andrews, pp. 5-8).

- **Photography in Service of the Arts:** In Chapter 2, Andrews reviews how photography assists other media such as painting, drawing, and illustration. How does he propose photography should support traditional fine arts rather than supplant them?

Answer) Andrews says that instead of competing, photography and painting can support each other. Photography helps painters to capture moments like expressions of people places, minute details, any movements and the lighting conditions. Artists can also take these photographs as references when they want to create their own paintings. Conversely, he argued that photographs should not replace human imagination or the artistic effort.

Photography is valuable art when it comes in helping an artist have better understanding of nature and improve their creative work (Andrews, pp. 11-13).

Part 2: Critical Quote Analysis

Deconstruct the three historical passages below. Address the accompanying analytical questions for each quote. At least 50 words per quote.

Quote 1 (Page 8)

> *"After all, it is a question of artistic feeling, and it is a great mistake to suppose that without this you can produce artistic work."*
> **— John Andrews, Studies in Photography, 1892**

1. What constitutes 'artistic feeling' in Andrews's framework?
2. How does this internal sensibility transform a purely mechanical routine into an authentic artistic process?

Answer) Artistic feeling is its ability to recognize beauty, showing of emotions, and make some creative decisions. Andrews believes that this quality is required to produce beautiful artwork. A camera can take the image accurate, but it will solely never decide what bring emotion in the scene. When the photographer opts for their subject, lightning they want and composition it makes an ordinary mechanical process into an authentic artistic experience.

Quote 2 (Page 12)

> *"Emerson has well expressed it when he defined art as 'Nature passed through the alembic of man.'"*
> **— Cited by John Andrews, p. 12**

1. An alembic is an apparatus historically employed for chemical distillation, purification, and transformation. Using this metaphor, explain what art is according to Ralph Waldo Emerson and John Andrews.
2. If nature provides the raw input, what specific intellectual, emotional, or aesthetic transformation occurs within the 'alembic of man'?

Answer) In this quote, Emerson uses a metaphor that means that art is transformed by nature by humans' imagination and their ability to understand. An alembic is someone who changes

the raw materials into different similarly, an artist also transforms his observations into creative expressions. Nature gives an artist the subject and he then includes his feelings into it, his life experiences, understandings, and his own vision. This means that the art is not just depicting the reality, but it is a way to represent the reality in their own creative way.

Quote 3 (Page 12)

> *"Photography is a most useful and curious invention and of the greatest value for the record of plain facts about persons and places, but it is not a fine art at all and can never be made one."*
> **— Philip Gilbert Hamerton, cited by John Andrews, p. 12**

1. Why does Philip Gilbert Hamerton assert that photography can never advance beyond the recording of 'plain facts'?
   2. What essential threshold must a medium cross to qualify as a 'fine art' under Hamerton's criteria?
   3. Contrast Hamerton's critique with Emerson's alembic: does photographic technology pass nature through human consciousness, or does the optical mechanism bypass human distillation entirely?
2.

Answer) Instead of creating original artistic interpretations Hamerton argues on the point that photography only records factual appearances. He believes that the fine art needs human imagination and transformation ability into an idealized expression. His view says that just the camera's mechanical process cannot succeed in this transformation. His ideas contradict with Emerson metaphor in which nature passes through human consciousness, Hamerton see photography as a technology which produces appearances directly. Andrew considers that Homerton's idea too extreme because photographers can do artistic judgement.

Part 3: The Family of the Arts and the Contemporary AI Controversy

Watch the assigned news broadcast covering Jason M. Allen, who entered and won first place in the digital arts division at the 2022 Colorado State Fair using the generative AI model Midjourney for his work Théâtre D'opéra Spatial. Synthesize Andrews's nineteenth-century analysis with this modern dispute by addressing the following prompts:

• **The Kinship of Media:** Andrews suggests that traditional painting and photography operate as sisters or members of the same creative family, each aspiring toward an aesthetic ideal through distinct instruments. How would you position digital art relative to traditional painting—are they sisters, cousins, or distinct lineages? More critically, where does generative AI belong? Can AI-generated imagery be admitted into the family of fine arts, or

does it occupy an entirely different technological category? Ground your defense in the definitions provided by Andrews, Emerson, and Hamerton.

Answer) I strongly believe that traditional painting, digital art, and AI-generated images all are in same creative group, even though each uses a different creation method. Traditional painting uses physical materials like paint, brushes, and canvas, while on the other hand digital art is created with technology and computer programs. The images that are created using AI is different because it uses written sets of instructions and prompts to produce images. Although these methods differ with each other, they can all express ideas and creativity. Andrews further explains that photography and traditional painting may use different methods, but they can still have artistic value and can be used to serve different purposes. I ponder that this same idea can also be applied to create AI-generated art. When a person uses his own thinking and imagination, puts thoughts into their prompts and take creative decisions about his final image, AI can help in creation of the art. However, I also believe there is a difference between using AI creativity and simply letting a computer create an image with little personal involvement. When little thought or effort goes into the process, it becomes hard to say how much of the final artwork truly belongs to the person who created it. This also brings up questions about who should receive credit for the artwork and what makes something original.

• **Evaluating the Colorado State Fair Verdict:** Was it fair for Jason M. Allen to enter and win this competition using Midjourney?
• If you align with Hamerton, explain why prompt-based synthetic generation fails to meet the standard of fine art.
• If you align with Andrews or Emerson, explain how composing text prompts, curating algorithmic variants, and upscaling outputs may function as 'artistic feeling' or the operation of the 'alembic of man'.

Answer) I think Jason Allen's win makes sense to some extent because the digital arts category allowed artists to use technology in their work. The artwork *Théâtre D'opéra Spatial*, was created using Midjourney and he won first place at the 2022 Colorado State Fair. Allen spent most of his time working on his prompts and he keep trying different versions of the images, choosing the ones he liked best, and making edits until he was happy with the result. This shows that he still had a role in making creative decisions throughout the process. At the same time, I can understand why traditional artists were frustrated and questioned whether the competition was fair. Many artists spend countless hours creating work by hand, counting solely on their talent and imagination. For them, competing against a

piece made with digital tools and software may feel unfair. Therefore, I think art competitions should have clear rules about whether AI-generated artwork is permitted. That way, everyone knows what to expect before entering, and participants understand how their work will be judged.

• Conclude with your own reasoned assessment: does utilizing generative AI represent an authentic artistic practice, or is it fundamentally an automated collation of statistical patterns?

Answer) In my opinion, AI-generated images become art when an individual puts his real thought and creativity into the process. For example, coming up with original ideas, thoughtful prompts, choosing how the image should look, and amend the results accordingly all involve creative decisions. I think this connects to Andrews's idea of artistic feeling because the individual employs their own thoughts and imagination to produce something meaningful. It also relates to Emerson's view that people can use their imagination to take things from nature and present them in their own creative way. However, I think there is a major difference between putting time and effort into creating an image and simply typing a short prompt and accepting whatever the computer generates. In that situation, the person has less control over the final artwork and may show less of their own creativity. Overall, I believe AI should be seen as another tool that artists can use rather than something that replaces human artists. What matters most is the personal thought, effort, and creativity a person puts into the artwork before it is finished.

Submission Guidelines and Evaluation Rubric

• Format: 2 to 3 typed pages (approximately 600-800 words), double-spaced, 12 pt font, 1-inch margins.
• Citation Standard: Include specific page citations for all direct references to John Andrews (1892). Cite relevant reporting details from the video case study.
• Submission Portal: Upload your completed analysis document as a PDF or Word document (.docx) to your GitHub repository to the Phase 2 folder as Assignment 2.2.

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Criteria	Weight	Performance Standards
Textual Comprehension	**20%**	Demonstrates deep, accurate understanding of John Andrews's arguments, technical distinctions, and views on composition; clearly differentiates

		Andrews's perspective from the historical critics he cites.
Quote Deconstruction	**15%**	Provides rigorous, nuanced analysis of 'artistic feeling,' Emerson's 'alembic of man,' and Hamerton's 'plain facts' critique, unpacking metaphorical and practical meanings.
Synthesis & Application	**15%**	Synthesizes 1890s lens-based mechanical debates with 2020s generative AI controversies with critical depth, using precise visual design vocabulary and coherent philosophical argumentation.
In class-Discussion	**50%**	Actively participates in the seminar discussion by presenting ideas from the written submission, offering concrete examples from John Andrews's text and the Colorado State Fair case study. Contributes comments that move beyond simple agreement or disagreement by grounding claims in the assigned concepts (such as "artistic feeling" or the "alembic of man"), building upon peers' arguments, and demonstrating sustained presence and active listening throughout the entire session